at work on the Thames, or some of those who are in the county gaols, under sentence of transportation, as may be thought most expedient. In the first place, let the surrounding wall, intended for full security against escapes, be completed, and proper lodges for the gatekeepers. Let temporary buildings, of the nature of barracks, be erected in some part of this enclosure which will be wanted the least, till the whole is finished. Let one or two hundred men, with their proper keepers, and under the directions of the builder, be employed in levelling the ground, digging out the foundation, serving the masons, sawing the timber and stone: and as I have found several convicts who were carpenters, masons, and smiths, these may be employed in their own branches of trade; since such work is as necessary and proper as any other in which they can be engaged. Let the people thus employed chiefly consist of those—whose term is nearly expired—or, who are committed for a short term; and as the ground is suitably prepared for the builders, the garden made, the wells dug, and the building finished, let those who are to be dismissed go off gradually; as it would be very improper to send them back to the hulks or gaols again. By this method, they may be kept most usefully employed; and at the same time, by regular labour, some degree of separation, and proper conduct of their overseers to them, they may perhaps be a little reformed: for, except their keepers, and the directors of the works, they will be no more intermixed with other people than where they are now, at Woolwich, Portsmouth, or Gosport. I have not considered this scheme superficially, though I can bear being told, it is absurd. Many have been reclaimed and made useful members of society, in foreign houses of correction, and have thanked God for their confinement in them: these houses are called in Holland *Verbeter huizen*, that is, bettering houses: and, the settled object in all such houses should be, to make men better; at least, more useful subjects. Their earnings constitute, in my opinion, but a secondary consideration: for surely, it is impossible to place any degree of profit in competition with the prospect of meliorating the minds of our fellow creatures.

"The object I am sensible is great, but it is useful. If I should not be able to accomplish this good work, I would still endeavour to bring materials, and lay the foundation; that others, of more skill, may afterwards undertake the benevolent task, and carry to perfection a plan, worthy of the great Sir William Blackstone, with whom I had the honour of much conversation on this

subject; a man, of such vast extent of capacity, as to have comprehended, in one enlarged view, the whole fabric of our laws; who was able to reduce them to a regular system; and, who further possessed, what is rarely united to great abilities, constancy to execute his immortal work."

[From *An Account of Lazarettos*, pp. 220–2.]

"A proper plan for the government of penitentiary houses is of great importance, and is more practicable than some suspect. I am aware indeed of the difficulty of accomplishing so arduous an undertaking as that of reforming criminals, and inuring them to habits of industry; yet, when it is for the public good, we ought to make experiments; and indeed, what have I been doing in collecting the regulations of some of the best directed houses of correction in Europe, and such as experience has proved to be practicable, but endeavouring to facilitate the execution of this useful design. The decency, regularity and order that I observed in the houses of correction in Holland, Hamburg, Berne, Ghent, Florence, etc., I am fully persuaded, proceeded, in a great degree, from the constant attention that is paid to impress the prisoners with a sense of religion, by plain, serious discourse, catechising and familiar instruction from the chaplains, together with the influence of a good example, both in them and the keepers. These circumstances make a much greater impression upon the minds of criminals, when in prison, than they would have done before they came there. We have too much adopted the gothic mode of correction, viz. by rigorous severity, which often hardens the heart; while many foreigners pursue the more rational plan of softening the mind in order to its amendment.

"I hope I shall be excused in repeating some general hints on this subject, as an outline for the government of such houses.

GENERAL HEADS OF REGULATIONS PROPOSED TO BE ESTABLISHED IN PENITENTIARY HOUSES OR HOUSES OF CORRECTION

"Security. Situation; contrivance of the building; lodging upstairs, or over arcades; clothes of two colours; turnstiles and low gates; alarm-bell; double doors, one iron-latticed; high wall surrounding; number and disposition of turnkeys; military guard if necessary; gaoler's windows looking into the yard; collar, ring, or somewhat of that kind to be worn for discovery on escapes; times of opening and shutting up to be strictly observed; caution in